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PHILOSOPHY OF LANGUAGE:

Fundamental Concerns

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iii) *Language and Thought: two faces of the coin (de Saussure)*

F. de Saussure clearly states that neither thought nor language can exist without the other, for they are just two faces of the same coin. Language does not simply express thought but systematises and structures it. Without language thought becomes fluid.⁵⁶ Here R. Harris is correct in saying that "Saussure roundly denies the possibility of pre-linguistic thought."⁵⁷ D. Davidson wonders "whether the speaker who can't find the right words has a clear idea" at all.⁵⁸ Rejecting the opinion that language serves but simply as a means of expressing already internally formed thought de Saussure goes further: the characteristic role of language with regard to thought is not to serve as a material phonetic means for expressing ideas, but to serve as intermediary between thought and language, under the conditions such that their union ends necessarily in a reciprocal delimitation of unity.⁵⁹ By the phrase "reciprocal delimitation of unity" Saussure underscores the point that language and thought are interdependent: just as

⁵⁶ F. de Saussure, *Cours de linguistique general*. In this world renowned publication de Saussure states: "*notre pensée n'est qu'une masse amorphe et indistincte. Prise in elle-même, la pensée est comme une nébuleuse où rien n'est nécessairement délimité. Il n'y a pas d'idées préétablies, et rien n'est distinct avant l'apparition de la langue.*" p. 155.

⁵⁷ R. Harris, *Language, Saussure and Wittgenstein. How to play games with words*. London. New York: Routledge, 1988, p. 29.

⁵⁸ D. Davidson, "Thought and talk", *op. cit.*, p. 232.

⁵⁹ The original text in French reads: "...le rôle caractéristique de la langue vis-à-vis de la pensée n'est pas de créer un moyen phonique matériel pour l'expression des idées, mais de servir d'intermédiaire entre la pensée et le son, dans des conditions telles que leur union aboutit nécessairement à des délimitations réciproques d'unité." F. de Saussure, *Cours de linguistique general*. p. 156.

there is no pre-existing pure thought awaiting verbal expression, so also there is no thought-free language to which thought must conform. Saussure stresses so vividly this inseparable nature of thought and language by presenting the two as two sides of a sheet of paper:

Language is again comparable to a leaf of paper: thought is the recto and sound [speech] the verso; one cannot cut the recto without at the time cutting the verso; the same with language, one cannot isolate neither thought nor the sound...⁶⁰

Language and thought, therefore, are interdependent, one relating to the other in an inseparable reciprocal unity. Heidegger pursues further this idea of reciprocity and interdependency between language and thought especially in the role he assigns to language in his theory of $\alpha\lambda\epsilon\theta\epsilon\iota\alpha$ (laying bare), and in his analysis of $\lambda\epsilon\gamma\epsilon\iota\nu$ (speech) and $\nu\omicron\epsilon\iota\nu$ (thinking), as we shall see immediately below.

iv) *The reciprocity between language and thought as revealed in Heidegger's analysis of $\lambda\epsilon\gamma\epsilon\iota\nu$ and $\nu\omicron\epsilon\iota\nu$*

For Heidegger, language plays a central role in thinking. One comes to understand why this is so when one understands that for Heidegger thinking is raising question about Being. To think is itself to make use of language. It is in trying to think out the exact words for expressing ourselves that language plays the most important role in our thinking.

But when does language speak itself as language?

Curiously enough, when we cannot find the right word for something that concerns us, carries us away, oppresses or

⁶⁰ "La langue est encore comparable à une feuille de papier: la pensée est le recto et le son le verso; on ne peut découper le recto sans découper en même temps le verso; de même dans la langue, on ne saurait isoler ni le son de la pensée, ni la pensée du son...." Ibid., p. 157.

encourages us. Then we leave unspoken what we have in the mind and . . . undergo moments in which language itself has distantly and fleetingly touched us with its essential being.⁶¹

Even when speech fails a man in the face of certain experience, he is not without language nor is he entirely silent, because the experience he is undergoing is in language. The experience is informing him and revealing to him. In such a situation, writes Heidegger, "He does no longer speak. Nor is he silent."⁶² What a poet, for example, does, says Heidegger, is to "put into language the experience he undergoes with language".⁶³ When the poet thinks, before ever he puts into words what he has thought, he has all the time been undergoing certain experience in language. His thought is by means of language. Thinking is most of the time in form of asking questions about the underlying principle of all realities, questions that go "to the *radix*, the root of all that is".

There can be no thought without language for where there is no language there is nothing: "Where word breaks off nothing may be."⁶⁴ Where there is no language there is no light, no information, no understanding. It is language that makes intelligibility possible because language is the spark and gleam for the mind. Man is "within language and with language before all else."⁶⁵ It is because man is endowed with language that he is capable of thinking. Thinking is, according to Heidegger, a craft, a handicraft (*Handwerk*) and only a being who is endowed with language is capable of handicraft, and

⁶¹ M. Heidegger, *On the Way to Language*, op. cit., p. 59.

⁶² *Ibid.* p. 114

⁶³ *Ibid.*

⁶⁴ H. Heidegger, *On The Way To Language*, op. cit., p. 60.

⁶⁵ *Ibid.* p. 112

"only when man speaks, does he think – not the other way around."⁶⁶

Heidegger exposes most clearly what he believes to be the relationship between language and thought in his analysis of the Greek verbs *λεγειν* (to speak) and *νοειν* (to think) as contained in Parmenides' passage:

"Χρητο λεγειν τε νοειν τε εον εμμεναι."

"One should both say and think that Being is."⁶⁷

λεγειν (*legein*) is interpreted by Heidegger variously as "say", "saying", "telling", "stating", "letting-lie-before-us", "making-to-appear". *Legein* has to do with laying bare, revealing, showing and letting appear. He translates *νοειν* (*noein*) as "think", "thinking", "perceiving", "taking-to-heart". Perceiving is to be understood here in the sense of active perception as distinguished from receptive passive sensual perception. It is language that lays Being bare, that reveals it and makes it possible for the mind to take it to heart, to think it. Logic which is "the theory of the *Logos* and its *λεγειν*" is itself the theory of thinking. We talk of thinking only where there is both *λεγειν* and *νοειν* for both "*λεγειν* and *νοειν* are seen as the definitive characteristic of the nature of thinking"⁶⁸ Thinking by its very nature contains the elements of both thinking and speech. It is in the unity of *λεγειν* and *νοειν* that "the nature of thinking first begins to emerge in one of its basic characteristics". To have a conception of thinking that lacks any of these two elements is, in Heidegger's opinion, a fundamental misconception of the true nature of thought.

⁶⁶ M. Heidegger, *What is called Thinking?* op. cit., p. 16.

⁶⁷ *Ibid.*, p. 171.

⁶⁸ *Ibid.*, p. 197.

The central role of *legein* in thinking is that it lays bare to the mind what is to be thought. The essence of language is that of "making-to-appear" and "letting-lie-before-us". Heidegger sees no other means than language through which Being can reveal itself to man for him to think. It is because of this central role of language in thinking that the science of thinking, logic, has to take its root from *legein*, *logos*.⁶⁹ *Legein* and *noein* go together inseparably by virtue of their original nature. *Legein* reveals reality to man and man perceives through *noein* what *legein* lays bare before him. Language and thought are inseparable because the co-ordination between $\lambda\epsilon\gamma\epsilon\iota\nu$ and $\nu\omicron\epsilon\iota\nu$ is not a co-ordination in series, rather "each inters into the other". They "enter upon and into one another, in a give-and-take". The relation between them "is not a patchwork of things and attitudes" rather it is "a conjunction". They are related in such a way that one is "co-natural with the other".⁷⁰ *Noein* (thinking) is determined by *legein* (language) in two senses: *noein* unfolds out of *legein* and *noein* is kept within *legein*.⁷¹ Trying to conceive thinking in the sense of *noein* alone is inadequate. The adequate conception of the essential nature of thinking necessarily includes *legein* and *noein* in their relation to Being which *legein* tells and which is "taken to heart", perceived, in *noein*. We can understand Heidegger as saying that thinking involves the reality being thought, the language by means of which the reality is represented to the mind, and the art of thinking itself.

From the above analysis of *legein* and *noein* it becomes clear that for Heidegger language and thought always go together. Both, as it were, form an inseparable whole. Language is not just the spoken words meant to express thought. Language is

⁶⁹*Ibid.*, p. 204)-

⁷⁰*Ibid.*, pp. 208 - 209.

⁷¹*Ibid.*, p.211.

part and parcel of the human essence having both internal and external dimensions. Heidegger considers the internal dimension of language to be of more importance than the external dimension: Being ($\epsilon\omicron\nu$) "*speaks* in our speech long before thinking gives attention and a name of its own to it."⁷² The Being(reality), speaks to man in language and man gives thought to the language spoken. Language, as it were, inspires thought.

Heidegger, however, does not identify language and thought. While language reveals and lets-lie-before-us the reality, thought enables us to take-to-heart, to perceive, and to reflect on, that which lies before us by means of language. The analysis Heidegger makes of $\lambda\epsilon\gamma\epsilon\iota\nu$ and $\nu\omicron\epsilon\iota\nu$ and how each is inseparably related to the other in a mutual give-and-take shows that language and thought are so closely related to each other that it is not possible to have one without the other, though each remains a different reality. Concerning the role of language in thinking Heidegger points out that language plays the role of informing the human mind and of revealing to it what is to be thought, and at the same time serves as the means by which thinking itself is done.

v) *Rejection of thinking as a mental process and as "entity" in the mind ("Later" Wittgenstein):*

On making his return journey to philosophy in 1929, Wittgenstein begins to criticise the identification of language and thought. His works from this time, especially the *Investigations*, are not explicit enough on the question of the relationship between language and thought. This inexplicitness follows from the fact that Wittgenstein considers it very difficult, if not impossible, to give the essential nature of

⁷² *Ibid.*, p. 235.

thinking. Because there is a variety of activities to which the term "thinking" applies, in the same way the relationship of language to these activities vary. This is what we read in the following passage:

...our language might possess a variety of different words: one for 'thinking out loud'; one for thinking as one talks to oneself in the imagination; one for a pause during which something or other floats before the mind, after which, however, we are able to give a confident answer. One word for a thought expressed in a sentence; one for the lightning thought which I may later 'clothe in words'; one for wordless thinking as one works.⁷³

Let me try to supply the English words that we normally use to refer to these variety of cases. The English word for referring to the "activity of thinking out aloud" is "soliloquising", that for the activity of "talking to oneself in the imagination" is "deliberating", the word for "a pause during which something floats before the mind" is "reflecting". The word for expressing thought in a sentence is "speaking", and that for "the lightning thought which may later be 'clothed in words'" (I have no idea for this), while the wordless thinking as one works is "concentrating". This means that soliloquising, deliberating, reflecting, speaking, concentrating and so on can each, in one sense or the other, be said to be a form of thinking. Wittgenstein wonders whether language comes to play in all these varieties of cases where the term "thinking" applies. He asks questions: "Can one think without speaking?"⁷⁴; "Is thinking a kind of speaking?"⁷⁵ In the case where we "think in language" there is no other process going in the secret of our mind different from the language, because in such a case "the

⁷³L. Wittgenstein, *Zettel*, edited by G. E. M. Anscombe and G. H. von Wright, tr. G. E. M. Anscombe. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1967), no. 122.

⁷⁴L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 327

⁷⁵*Ibid.*, paragraph 330

language is itself the vehicle of thought.”⁷⁶ Thus, in speaking and in deliberating language serves as the vehicle of thinking. The same is the case in soliloquy.⁷⁷ In other cases, Wittgenstein becomes more careful, warning against rushing into a conclusion that they are done without language, as he does in the following passage:

If there were only quite few people who could get the answer to a sum without speaking or writing, they could not be adduced as testimony to the fact that calculating can be done without signs. The reason is that it would not be clear that these people were ‘calculating’ at all.⁷⁸

It may be that such people are so acquainted with the sum that they automatically, that is without really calculating (*rechnen*), get to the required answer; or perhaps they are endowed with what Hilary Putnam would call “non-natural mental powers of directly ‘grasping forms’”⁷⁹. If the answer is so automatic, then there is no “thinking”, no “calculating” in the normal senses of these terms. It is not uncommon to hear people who, to show that they have been very much habituated with certain mathematical problems, boast that they can supply the answer “without thinking”. If no thinking is done in order to give the answer, then the giving of the answer is not the case of thinking without language. In the same way, Wittgenstein doubts the genuineness of the report of Mr. Ballard who claims to have had thoughts about God and about the world as a deaf-mute, before ever he was initiated into the rudiments of language, a report which William James uses as a proof that thought is possible without language. “Are you sure”, Wittgenstein doubts, “that this is the correct translation of

⁷⁶*Ibid.*, paragraph 329

⁷⁷*Ibid.*, paragraph 331

⁷⁸L. Wittgenstein, *Zettel*, no. 109

⁷⁹H. Putnam, *Reality and Reason: Philosophical Papers*. Vol. 3
Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 1983, p. 1.

wordless thought into words? . . . I do not know what conclusions one can draw from them about the past of the man who recounts them."⁸⁰ Therefore, "Ballard's testimony (in James) cannot convince one that it is possible to think without a language."⁸¹ The words with which a person reports his thought is itself part and parcel of the thought.⁸²

Later Wittgenstein rejects the notion that thought is a sort of entity in the mind or a mental process.⁸³ In line with this, he also rejects the expressionist view about the relationship between language and thought. There is no thought or idea *already made* which exists in any secret inner place waiting to be expressed. If the thinking person is working, his thought is not a secret process accompanying the physical work he is doing. He is "concentratedly" or "thinkingly" working, that is all. The concentration or the thinking and the working form one unity. The thinking is in the working. Looking for any other psychological entity or process different from the work being done is, in Wittgenstein's opinion, a misunderstanding of the term "thinking". In the same way, if the thinking person is speaking, there is nothing hidden in his mind that is manifested or expressed by his language. He thinks in the language he speaks. He does not finish his thinking in a sort of "private language"⁸⁴ and then after begins to translate it into the public

⁸⁰L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 342

⁸¹ L. Wittgenstein, *Zettel*, no. 109. Also see *Zettel*, no. 1

⁸²L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 343

⁸³*Ibid.*, paragraph 330

⁸⁴ Wittgenstein denies both the reality and the possibility of the private language. By private language he means the language whose individual words "are to refer to what can only be known to the person speaking; to his immediate private sensations. So another person cannot understand the language" (*Philosophical Investigations*, 243). Jerry A. Fodor contests this denial of the private language, arguing that each person possesses a "language of thought" which is private to him.

language. "What did the thought consist in, as it existed before its expression?"⁸⁵ Wittgenstein makes caricature of the expressionist view in his reference to the French politician who once said that it is a peculiarity of the French language that its words occur in the sequence of thought. This politician is contrasting French language with German or Latin language in which a person "first has to think it, and then . . . arranges the words in that queer order".⁸⁶ The French politician commits the error of believing that the German speaker's mode of thinking is different from his (German's) way of speaking. This error, says Wittgenstein, "arises from the notion that thought is an essentially different process going on independently of the expression of the thoughts."⁸⁷ A child learns to talk and to think at the same time not one *before* or *after* the other. A child does not learn the sense of multiplication *before* or *after* it learns multiplication.⁸⁸

For Wittgenstein, however, thinking is not reducible to language because there are many forms of thinking in which language hardly comes in. For instance, in the case of doing something concrete, say dancing or driving. The dancer or the driver is thinking what he is doing, or rather is "thinkingly" dancing or driving. He hardly articulates his dancing or driving in language. He does not need to do so. He does not "say to himself" I will raise my right leg, I will lower the left hand, I must turn the steering a little bit to the right etc. Such a "saying to himself" does not arise in this case. And there is no other

⁸⁵ L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 335

⁸⁶ *Ibid.*, paragraph 336. Confer also L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Grammar*, ed. Rush Rhees, tr. Anthony Kenny. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1974), p. 107

⁸⁷ L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Grammar*, ed. Rush Rhees, tr. Anthony Kenny. (Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1974), p. 107.

⁸⁸ *Loc. Cit.*

psychological process going on in the head of the driver or the dancer apart from the driving or the dancing. The dancing or the driving and the thinking form an inseparable unity. In short, for Wittgenstein, there is nothing extra to the action that is taking place before us. The same is the case with having intention. I can articulate my intention in words the first time I am forming the intention, say the intention of becoming a University professor. But then, this intention can be there for years, and I can say that I have been *thinking* all these years of becoming a University professor. In this sense *having intention* is a form of *thinking*. Intention "does not have genuine duration."⁸⁹ As such, it is not necessarily nor always, though it can sometimes be, in language.⁹⁰ The same is the case with hope, belief, expectation, anticipation, knowing and understanding. Understanding or knowing is not a mental process or a mental entity. It is not always that a person is conscious of what he understands or what he knows. Understanding is *ability* to do something.⁹¹ It is neither a mental process nor a psychological entity. So the question whether it is in language or not is nonsensical. In the form of thinking where such a question reasonably arises, for instance in the case of silently saying "saying to oneself", soliloquy, speaking etc. Wittgenstein's answer is that "the language is itself the vehicle of thought."⁹² If a politician, for example, is standing before the crowd in a political rally speaking in order

⁸⁹L. Wittgenstein, *Zettel*, no. 45.

⁹⁰ Theologians distinguish between actual and habitual intention. Actual intention is always articulated in language, while habitual intention is not always so articulated.

⁹¹ Cf. *Zettel* 84-5, *Philosophical Investigations* 150, *Philosophical Grammar*, pp. 44-45, 47, 50, 66, 81. In these passages Wittgenstein describes understanding or knowing as an ability. Ability is neither a process nor an entity. Thus, the question whether it is with or without language does not arise.

⁹²L. Wittgenstein, *Philosophical Investigations*, paragraph 329.

to convince the crowd to vote for him, there is nothing going on in his head in addition to what he is saying. Here language and thought remain inseparable; both go hand-in-hand.

vi) *Language of Thought and the Defence of the Mental*
(Fodor & Chomsky)

Wittgenstein's denial of the mental processes and mental entities is perceived by some thinkers, like J. A. Fodor and N. Chomsky, as a negation of all forms of cognitive sciences and a reduction of thinking to language and other forms of behaviours. Both Fodor and Chomsky set out to defend the reality and the importance of mental faculties in the proper understanding of man and his behaviour. Their concern with the defence of the mental does not, however, make them deny or neglect the role of language in thinking. They rather view language as an essential integral part of the human cognition.

Fodor (1975)⁹³ holds that language is at the very basis of every form of thought. However, one has to take care in making a

⁹³ J. A. Fodor, *The Language of Thought*. Sussex: The Harvester Press, 1975. In this book Fodor sets out to defend the possibility of the philosophy of mind and the possibility of cognitive psychology. In his opinion there are two forms of "reductionism" that militate against the science of the mind: logical behaviourism and physiological reductionism. Reductionism in general is "the view that all the special sciences reduce to physics" (p. 10). Logical behaviourism is a quest to reduce psychological (mental) processes to mere language behaviours. He argues that there is always mental operation that explains the behaviour of a person. As such, any attempt to explain the behaviour of an organism without taking into account the organism's mental processes is "fundamentally incoherent" (p. 2). He accuses Wittgenstein and Ryle (both logical behaviourists) of having killed cognitive psychology: "Ryle and Wittgenstein killed this sort of psychology some time about 1945. Physiological reductionism is an attempt to reduce every psychological events to physiological events; e.g., intelligent events are to be studied by the physiological analysis of the brain and nervous system. In other words, physiological reductionism is a sort of"

hasty conclusion here because Fodor does not talk simply of the natural language but of a special form of language which he calls "the language of thought". This type of language is innate in man and is the basis of all cognitive, all computational, activities of the mind. Fodor's theory of computation (cf. pp. 64ff) is very central in his quest to revive the philosophy of mind and the cognitive psychology which, he says, have been killed by Wittgenstein and Ryle. All cognitive activities, according to him, are computational in character and computation presupposes some mental representations or mental models, (cf. pp. 27, 51). But then "there is no internal representation without an internal language" (p. 55). Since man is capable of computation, there must be in him some mental representations, and if there are mental representations in him he must possess an "internal language" and this is the language of thought.

What is really the nature of this language of thought and what is its role in cognitive functions of an organism? The first characteristic of the language of thought is that it is an inner (or internal) language. It is quite different from the natural language of a given community, e. g. English, French, Igbo etc.

neurologism". Fodor rejects these and all other forms of reductionism and goes on to prove the reality of mental processes, especially the reality of mental language which he calls "language of thought". This is the aim of Fodor: "... what I am proposing to do is resurrect the traditional notion that there is a 'language of thought'... ." (p. 51). The language of thought is "a language in which the universals, the candidate grammars, and the observed utterances are represented", (p. 58). This type of language is hypothetical. It is not the natural language because natural languages are learned. To learn the natural language, the child needs another language, a type of meta-language by means of which he learns his mother tongue and other natural languages. This meta-language is the language of thought. All the references to this book is made in the body of my work by simply indicating the pages.

Fodor makes this point clear when he says that "although computation presupposes a representational language, it does *not* presuppose that that language must be one of the ones which function as vehicles of communication between speakers and hearers." (pp. 56-7). It is not the natural language because to learn a natural language (which is a computational activity) one needs this other language. Fodor argues that "one cannot learn a first language unless one already has a system capable of representing the predicates in that language *and their extensions*" and "that system cannot be the language that is being learned". Since the first natural language is learned, "at least some cognitive operations are carried out in languages other than natural language", (p. 64). The language other than natural language is, of course, the language of thought. Thus, the major characteristic of the language of thought is that it is *innate*. It is not *learned*; it is simply *known*. "My view", writes Fodor, "is that you can't learn a language unless you already *know* one. It isn't that you can't learn a language unless you've already *learned* one." (p. 65). To learn a natural language is to translate it into the language of thought which the child knows by nature, (p. 67). Another characteristic of the language of thought is that it is *private* to each thinker. The language of thought is not the public language of communication. Thus, he disagrees with Wittgenstein's argument against "private language". It is not only that private language is possible, but there are private languages, he maintains.⁹⁴

⁹⁴Fodor does not, however, state whether he means the same thing as Wittgenstein by the term "private". For Wittgenstein a thing is private when it is logically impossible to be communicated to another person. Thus, a private language is the language that cannot be understood by any other person except the speaker, (PU 243). Thus, even if the speaker wishes to communicate it, he cannot do so due the nature of this language. Wittgenstein says that such thing, be it language, sensation, process etc. does not exist. If Fodor does not use the term "private" in this sense (which I doubt he does), he needed not worry about private language argument.

Fodor is of the view that language of thought is enough for any organism to carry out all forms of cognitive activities it is capable of. If a person makes use of natural language (as some do) in his thinking, it is only accidental. He does not even accept the opinion of some thinkers that although natural languages are not indispensable at the initial cognitive stages, but once learned they improve the cognitive powers and performances of the child. "Nothing", he argues, "can be expressed in natural language that can't be expressed in the language of thought. For if something could, we couldn't learn the natural language formula that expresses it." (p. 84). He goes on to say that a person cannot learn "a language whose expressive power is greater than that of a language that one already knows". He cannot learn "a language whose predicates express extensions not expressible by those of a previously available representational system"; he cannot learn "a language whose predicates express extensions not expressible by predicates of the representational system whose employment mediates the learning", (p. 86). In short, "one can't learn a conceptual system richer than the conceptual system that one starts with", (p. 97). Fodor's 'language of thought' is therefore completely determined right from the beginning and does not admit of any development. By nature man, with all his faculties, is full of potentials, always open to actualization and in continuous development. Man's potentials, man's faculties, are actualized within a given environmental conditions. Fodor's 'language of thought' which is perfect at birth is not in line with the nature of man.

As for the role of the language of thought in cognition, we have seen that it is the basis of all mental activities in the sense that it is what makes all forms of representations possible. All cognitive activities are computational in character and all

computations are by means of representations or "mental models" as Fodor sometimes refers to them. Language of thought also plays a very important role in the learning of the natural language which an organism needs for communicating with other organisms or even with machines. The importance of language of thought is that it is the bedrock of all computations. One can, therefore, correctly say that Fodor is of the opinion that language is indispensable in thinking, only that the language needed for thinking is not the natural language. There is no pure thought, because thinking is a form of computation and there is no computation without some representations or models. Language is not simply for expressing thought, because there is nothing to express were language not there before hand. It is language that makes the formation of thought possible. Noam Chomsky, in his turn and like Fodor, tries to restore the science of the mind which the behaviourists have dismissed as a useless venture.

Reading through Chomsky's enormous works on the biological origin and acquisition of language, one sees immediately that he defends the position that language and thought are independent biological faculties. Ontologically and structurally language and thought are two separate "mental organs". It is on their functional level that one can have some influence over the other.

We may conceive the mind as a system of "mental organs", the language faculty being one. Each of these organs has its specific structure and function, determined in general outline by our genetic endowment, *interacting* in ways that are also biologically determined in large measure to provide the basis for our mental life.⁹⁵(emphasis, mine).

⁹⁵ N. Chomsky, *Rules and Representations*. Oxford: Basil Blackwell, 1980(1980), *op. cit.*, p. 241.

Chomsky defends the innate concepts or rather what he calls “preexisting concepts”, that is, concepts prior to words. It seems that he believes in the existence of some kind of wordless language which makes it possible for these “preexisting concepts” which a child has before it comes to “label” them. When we acquire a social language “we simply learn the label that goes with the preexisting concepts”.⁹⁶ For Chomsky, certain thought is possible without language, even though language is very important in many of our cognitive activities. For a proper functioning of the human cognition, language is needed.

Without this capacity [language] it might have been possible to “think thoughts” of a certain restricted character, but with the capacity in place, the same conceptual apparatus would be freed for the construction of new thoughts and operations such as inference involving them, and it would be possible to express and interchange these thoughts.⁹⁷

Chomsky is convinced that language is very essential in all mathematical and geometrical concepts for “there couldn’t be a mathematical capacity without a language capacity. . . we can have the relevant thoughts about geometrical space because we have language.”⁹⁸ He illustrated this point by calling attention to the fact that deaf people (people whose language has been affected in some way) cannot develop certain thinking processes. Thus, “there is a *tight relation* between problems of language and the development of thinking processes”.⁹⁹ The case of a said child brought up in isolation without any opportunity to social language proves the point Chomsky is

⁹⁶ N. Chomsky, *Language and Problems of Knowledge*. The Managua Lectures. Cambridge, Massachusetts, London: The MIT Press, 1988, p. 191.

⁹⁷*Ibid.*, p. 170.

⁹⁸*Ibid.*, p. 184.

⁹⁹*Ibid.*, p. 196 (emphasis mine).

making about "tight relation" between language and thought. Because this child grew up in isolation from the human language, "her intellectual deficits were enormous". Chomsky concludes:

The fact is that if you have not developed language, you simply don't have access to most of human experience, and if you don't have access to human experience, then you're not going to be able to think properly. . . ."¹⁰⁰

Thus, even if certain kinds of thinking may be possible without language, proper normal human thinking is impossible without language. Chomsky assigns two major functions to language, the *storing* of information and the *using* of information: "the language faculty has at least two different components: a 'cognitive system' that stores information in some manner, and performance systems that make use of this information for articulation, perception, talking about the world, asking questions, telling jokes, and so on. The language faculty has an input receptive system and an output production system. . . ."¹⁰¹ My thesis goes further in saying that it is language itself that makes the information possible for, where there is no language there is no information. In saying that language stores information Chomsky acknowledges the role of language in memory; and in describing language as the performance system that enables us to articulate, perceive etc., he recognizes the importance of language in understanding the world. The human cognitive system is "modified in response to linguistic experience".¹⁰² The position of Chomsky with regard to the relationship between language and thought is clear. The two are separate biological faculties or even biological "organs",

¹⁰⁰*Ibid.*

¹⁰¹ N. Chomsky, "Language and Nature", *Mind*. 104 (1995), p. 12. See also N. Chomsky, *Language and Thought*, Wakefield, Rhode Island&London: Moyer Bell, 1993, p. 47.

¹⁰²*Ibid.*, p. 13.

each determined by certain biological factors. The independent origins of the two faculties, however, do not negate the interdependence between them in their functions. Language, as we have just seen, plays essential role in the proper functioning of the human mind and in the formation of thought. Both are tightly related to each other and they interact "in a large measure to provide the basis for our mental life."¹⁰³ The interactions between language and thought "are dense and close".¹⁰⁴

vii) *A reconciliation of Monistic and Dualistic Views*
(Géza Révész¹⁰⁵)

Révész tries a reconciliation of monism and dualism with regard to the relationship between language and thought. The dualists are correct in maintaining that language and thought are different from each other, but then they go to the extreme of treating them as being totally separate from each other. The monists in turn score the point of noticing the close relationship between language and thought, though they are wrong in making the two faculties identical.

The first task for Révész is that of showing the differences between language and thought. He sees these differences in the functions, intentions and structures of these two faculties. Thinking and language cannot be identified because in examining the function, the intention and the structure, the rules and the content of each, one finds that although each influences the other, they remain two separate cognitive activities. There exists an essential difference between

¹⁰³ N. Chomsky, *Rules and Representations*, op. cit., p. 84.

¹⁰⁴ N. Chomsky, *Language and Thought*, op. cit., p. 34.

¹⁰⁵ See Géza Révész, "Denken und Sprechen", *Acta Psychologica*, 10 (1954), pp. 2 - 50. All the references to this paper are made in the body of the thesis by simply noting the page.

functions of thought and the functions of language. While the function of thought is a logical function, that of language is a symbolical function (p. 7). With regard to intentions, while thought is personal in its intent, language is social. Thought has knowledge intention while language has understanding intention (p. 8). I understand Révész as saying here that when a person thinks, his intention is to know or to learn, but when he speaks he wants to be understood. In other words, while thinking is knowledge oriented, speaking is understanding, or rather communication, oriented. This distinction by Révész is not totally correct. It is not always that language is social in its intention, and it is also a fact that often thought is social in its intention. An anthropologist who spends sleepless nights thinking on how to resolve the social problem of ethnicity or the scientist on how to overcome the problem of cancer, is such a thought personal? Do we not sometimes speak without any intention of being understood by anybody, without the intention of communicating? For example, a person can speak when he simply wants to express his emotions even in private.

As for the difference in the structures of language and thought, Révész points out that the rules of thinking and those of speaking are not the same. The rules that govern thought differ from those that govern language. Thinking is governed by psychological and logical rules, while language is governed by language rules and regulations and by familiarity with the language.¹⁰⁶ In thinking, the grammatico-syntactic form ("grammatisch-syntaktische Form") plays no (or a negligible) role. One does not need to observe all the rules of syntax and

¹⁰⁶ Das Denken wird von psychologischen Gesetzen und logischen Gesetzen, die Sprache von Sprachgesetzen geregelt.

all the grammatical rules while thinking. In speaking, however, one is bound to observe these rules as strictly as possible. This distinction again is not 100% correct. Have the rules of language really nothing to do with psychology? It is, of course, an undeniable fact that language has many psychological factors. If it is so, how correct is Révész in attributing the rules of psychology and even of logic only to thought and not to language? If this distinction is a way of denying the mental aspect of language, then it is totally false for, language, as I have maintained all through, has both genetic and environmental aspects. In trying to show how language and thought differ from each other, Révész exaggerates certain things.

The above differences notwithstanding, Révész recognizes the close relationship between language and thought. He asks: Is every act of speech accompanied by or based on thought processes? Is every single act of thinking accompanied by or based on language? (p. 10). In general, he answers in affirmative arguing that a thinking being necessarily speaks and that a speaking being necessarily thinks (p. 12). He affirms the indispensable role of thought in language because one cannot imagine a person who speaks and at the same time lacks the ability to think (p. 14). Language is existentially dependent on the thought function. "Words without thought never to heaven go", he cites Shakespeare, *Hamlet*, Act III (p. 20).

To the second question, whether language plays an essential role in every single act of thought, Révész responds in the affirmative.¹⁰⁷ In his opinion, many of those who deny the

¹⁰⁷ He replies in the words of the famous German language scholar and philosopher, Wilhelm von Humboldt: "Das Sprechen ist eine notwendige Bedingung des Denkens des Einzelnen in abgeschlossener Einsamkeit." (p. 22).

essential role of language in thinking do so because of the cases of wordless thinking. But then, one must distinguish between wordless thinking (*wortlose Gedanken*) and thinking without language (*sprachloses Denken*). Wordless thinking is not to be identified with thinking without language (p. 24). The cases of wordless thinking should not make us conclude that there are thoughts free from language. Thought can be wordless but at the same time not free from language because wordless thoughts are founded on language ("*wortlose Gedankensprachlich fundiert sind*") (p. 43). Thought is inseparable from language because the existence of thought is bounded to that of language (p. 24).

Révész points out the types of thinking in which language is obviously indispensable. In creative thinking, for instance, language plays such an essential role that it is not easy to distinguish language function from that of thought. The thought contents and language contents are here so intimately interwoven with each other. The conceptual thought is another kind of thought where language is clearly indispensable. The conceptual thought is always a language thought (p. 26). Here thought and language work together as equivalent factors. In conceptual thought language is not merely a means of expressing thought but is a special means of thought (*Denkmittel*). It is, however, not only in creative and conceptual thinking that language plays essential role. Every form of thinking: - everyday thinking, scientific thinking and artistic thinking, even discursive and intuitive thinking- makes use of language forms, language habits and language schema (p. 40). Révész concludes that in the very idea of being human and of cognition thought and language, are mixed up and form one unity (p. 46). Therefore, any dichotomy between thought and language cannot be correct.

Conclusion on the Problem of Thought and Language

The two extreme views – monism and dualism – on the problems of the relationship between thought and language are obviously not correct. Language cannot correctly be identified with thought. It is not in all the cases where the word 'thought' applies can the word 'language' apply. This is clear in the subtle analysis Wittgenstein has made on the different "manifestations of life" where the term "thinking" is used. Even to talk at all of the relationship between language and thought logically implies that the two are different. To make them identical is a way of telling us not to talk of the relationship between language and thought, because in that sense the two are but one and the same thing. The term 'thought' can be understood in the sense of the verb-noun 'thinking'. Thinking is a conscious intellectual activity. Thought can be a subsistent only in the secondary sense of the result of a person's thinking, for example, the thought of Aristotle, the thought of Shakespeare etc. Language appears to me to be a means, a means of getting informed, e.g. when a person is before the world or before an event that speaks to him/her in one form of language or the other, or when a person reflects, deliberates, calculates etc. Language is also a means of informing the other - a means of communication by speaking, looks, gestures, signs etc. Language is not an activity, though there is the activity of using language, like speaking language.

All the same, we cannot separate language from thinking as the dualists try to do, because "the connection between the human psyche and speech is far more subtle and complicated than one realizes".¹⁰⁸ Some of the dualists (spiritualists) exaggerate the

¹⁰⁸ R. N. Anshen, "Preface" to N. Chomsky, *Language and Thought*, op. cit., p. 9. On the role of language in the human cognition Anshen writes: "Language not only articulates, connects and infers, it also envisages, and the intuitive grasping of language is the primary act and function of that one

autonomy and "purity" of thought while others consider thought as entities in the mind. If thoughts are really entities, be they innate or formed from experience, they don't, of course, need language. Whenever ideas are considered as entities existing on their own, dualism is inevitable. Plato considered them so and had to "create" a separate world (the world of Forms) for them. St. Augustine did consider them so and had to locate their abode in the mind of God. From Descartes onwards the dichotomy has to be between the mind which is the abode of ideas and the body which is bewitched by deceptive experiences and false opinions. It is, thus, not surprising that after Descartes the science of the mind has to separate itself from other sciences. In line with Wittgenstein, I am arguing against the view that thoughts are entities in the mind. It is this view which dichotomizes language and thought. Here is the core of the problem we are discussing: the problem of the relation between language and thought. It is also here that the whole problem of meaning finds its origin. Locke would like us to inquire into the entities in the mind/brain/head of the speaker in order to understand the words he is making use of. Language does nothing but expresses these hidden entities in the mind/brain/head of the speaker. Wittgenstein, as we have seen, refutes vehemently the opinion that thought is an entity in the mind. He denies the reality of any *private* "psychological processes" in the mind. It is a misunderstanding

and single power which is called reason. For it is then that we may pass from, the passive acceptance of sense-data to a fresh, constructive, and spontaneous insight into the universe. Language thus becomes indispensable not only for the construction of the world of thought but also for the construction of the world of perception, both of which constitute the ultimate nexus of an intelligible communion, spiritual and moral between all of us.", pp. 11 - 12. We are able to form universal ideas from our perception of the particulars thanks to our language.

of the proper nature of language that leads a person to treat it as a mere means of expressing "a queer *process*" called thought.¹⁰⁹

The conception of thought as entity in the mind is also the origin of the 19th century German Psychologism propagated by Fries and Beneke which holds that the only true method for any meaningful philosophical inquiry is the method of self-observation (or introspection). This, according to them, is the only way to establish a secure truth. This philosophical school is an offshoot of Cartesian introspective method. Psychologism, in line with Locke's theory of meaning, locates meaning or the truth of words and sentences in the mental or psychological processes. M. Dummett defines psychologism as,

the thesis that an account of the meanings of words must be given in terms of the mental processes which they arouse in speaker or hearer or which are involved in acquiring a grasp of their sense (or the stronger thesis that these mental processes are what we are referring to when we use words).¹¹⁰

Frege, especially in his work *Die Grundlagen der Arithmetik* (1884), rejects psychologism saying that it leads to subjectivism. Subjectivism renders positive science impossible. Frege asserts that the meaning of a word is objective and not subjective. It is the objective content of a word that determines its meaning. The reference of any word is the object or event in the external world, outside the mind of the speaker.¹¹¹ Thought (thinking) is neither a psychological process going on the secret places of a person or

¹⁰⁹ "In our failure to understand the use of a word we take it as the expression of a queer *process*." (PI 196).

¹¹⁰ M. Dummett, *Truth and other Enigmas*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press, 1978, p. 88.

¹¹¹ Confer R. Sternfeld, *Frege's Logical theory*. 1966, pp. 20 - 21.

an entity in the mind which a person expresses when the need arises. Thus, expressionism is not correct.

In line with Frege, M. Dummett (1993)¹¹² exposes the fallacy involved in expressionist view, the view which he describes as "the conception of language as a code for thought" (p. 99). The fundamental fallacy of this view is that it presumes that the human mind is capable of grasping certain concepts prior to language which only expresses these concepts (*Ibid.*). "We need language", according to expressionist view, "only because we happen to lack the faculty of telepathy, that is, of the direct transmission of thought." (p. 97). This is wrong because there is no thought in the mind independent of language that could have been transmitted by the faculty of telepathy. It is the task of philosophers of language in line with Frege, says Dummett, to repudiate the expressionist views. It is wrong "to ascribe concepts and thoughts to people independently of their language" because, according to him, "for any but the simplest concepts, we cannot explain what it is to grasp them independently of the ability to express them in language." (*Ibid.*) The term "language" here is to be understood in its wide sense in which language includes the natural languages, sign languages, body languages, mathematical and other symbols, paintings etc.

The point that Dummett is making is that there is no concept in form of entity in the mind. It is false to think of the concepts in the mind which precede a knowledge of any language. For a true understanding of the relationship between

¹¹² M. Dummett, *The Seas of Language*. Oxford: Clarendon Press, 1991. The reader is invited to read in particular chapter 3 entitled "What do I Know when I Know a Language?" All the references to this work in the two paragraphs of my work are made in the body of the work by simply stating the relevant pages.

language and thought, the expressionist view must be replaced "by some account of the understanding of a language that makes no appeal to the prior grasp of the concepts that can be expressed in it. Such an account presents language, not just as a means of expressing thought, but as a *vehicle* for thought." (p. 99). What a person understands he understands in a language.¹¹³

In most cases thinking is a conscious activity. It is wrong to conceive thought as entity in the mind. When I say, for instance, my thought (idea) about a particular thing is A or B, I mean that I *am thinking* that that thing is A or B. In this case A or B is not a dormant entity in my mind. When I am asked: "What is your idea about X?" I answer by saying what I *am thinking* about X because the question is just the same as "What *do you think* about X?" I don't store any idea of X anywhere in me (head, brain or mind), even in the case where X is a past event. I have had the experience of X and have thought or understood something from the experience of X. As long as I am not thinking about X or about what I have understood about it, X is not in my mind. When I come to think about it either due to some personal reflection or by some present external experience that call up the experience of X, e.g., the question on my idea about X, I then think afresh about X. My idea or my thought about X is what I *am thinking* here

¹¹³Dummett interprets Wittgenstein's statement "To understand a sentence is to understand a language" (cf. PI 199) as meaning that a person's understanding on hearing a sentence is not any additional psychological process in the mind to the fact of his understanding the language spoken. Dummett writes: "He [Wittgenstein] did not mean that . . . you would not understand the sentence in the same way if you knew only a fragment of the language to which it belonged. He meant, rather, that, given you understand the *language*, that you are, as it were, in that *state* of understanding, nothing need happen, in which your understanding of the sentence consists, no act of understanding, other than your hearing that sentence." (p. 99)

Descartes is another outstanding author who maintains a dualistic view about the relationship between language and of thought. For him language plays no role in the constitution of thought. Thought exists purely independent of language for a thinking mind can exist independent of the body. The fact that those born deaf and dumb are in the habit of themselves inventing certain signs by which they express themselves is, for Descartes, a proof that there is thought without language.¹⁸ Thought exists in the human mind independently of language. It is only from time to time that thought needs expressing itself overtly, and it is only when such a need arises that language comes into play. Language is only used "*pour déclarer aux autres nos pensées*" ("for declaring to others our thoughts").¹⁹

Descartes' extension of the term thought to such activities as imagining (*imaginer*) and feeling (*sentir*) does not allow language any role in thinking. One does not always need language in order to imagine; less still does one need it in order to feel. In short, language plays no role in feeling, unless for explaining to others how we feel. For Descartes, language is not needed for thinking; it is only needed for the expression of thought. Thought exists and functions independently of language.

¹⁸ It is, however, contestable whether it is the deaf/dumb man who invented the sign himself or whether he learnt from those "usually in his company" who have invented these signs as a special type of language with which they communicate with their handicapped companion. Can one not say that the deaf and dumb thinks by means of this special kind of language?

¹⁹ R. Descartes, *Discours de la méthode*, 5ème partie. (*Discuss on The Method*, 5th part.)

and now about X. If I am thinking nothing about X, then I have *no idea* about X.

The expressionists argue that language does not come into play in the formation of ideas because it happens that often one looks for words to express the ideas one has. That a person looks for words to express his thoughts does not, however, imply that such thoughts are free from words. A friend of mine, for instance, was talking with me. He wanted to use the English term "lukewarm" but did not succeed in reaching at this word. For sure, he was looking for this word in order to express his thought precisely, but it does not mean that he was not thinking this idea in words. When he tried to get at this word and did not succeed he said to me: "Something which is neither hot nor cold, what the French call *tiède*." Then I said "Lukewarm" and he shouted "Exactly!" This shows that while looking for the word "lukewarm" to express what he was thinking, this my friend was already thinking of "something neither cold nor hot" and, of course, he was thinking of it in these words. From the general behaviour of people when they think and from our study of the nature of language (as a means of informing and of representing), and our study of the nature of thought (as the conscious intellectual activity of the mind), I maintain that language plays an essential role in thinking. Language plays the role of informing the human mind on what to think and where there is no such information there is nothing to think about. The human mind is incapable of thinking in the absence of language. Language also plays the role of storing thoughts. What do I mean by "storing thoughts"? How and where are thoughts stored? Thoughts are never stored as entities in the head. They are stored in the culture of a given people, in music, in paintings, in oral traditions (e.g. in stories, proverbs, wise saying etc.), in writings, in printing, in computersoft wares. People's way of life (culture), music,

paintings, writing, printing etc. are all forms of language and it is in them that thoughts are recorded and stored. Therefore, language and thought, notwithstanding the fact that they are two different realities, are inseparable from each other.